

Session 5: The Cyclical Pattern of Genesis 1-11

Key Takeaways

- Genesis 1-11 contains two cycles of a design pattern, emphasizing themes and questions that will drive the rest of the biblical story that leads to Jesus.
- Studying Genesis 1-11 trains you to see the sequence of themes that acts as a blueprint for later biblical writing.

Patterns in the Creation Story

The prologue of Genesis 1 (1:1-2) and the epilogue (1:31-2:3) have been designed as a macro frame around the internal sequence of six days, emphasizing the sevenfold symbolism of God’s actions and the culmination of the entire narrative in the seventh day. Notice how the key words of the opening prologue (“created,” “skies,” “land”) as well as the 1x7 and 2x7 design of 2:1-2 are taken up and completed in the prologue with the same words and the 3x7 design.

1:1 Summary Prologue

In the beginning, God **created** **the skies and the land** [7 words]

1:2 Exposition of Prologue in 3 Lines

Now, **the land** was wild and waste (תהו ובהו *tohu va-vohu*)
and darkness was over the face of the deep abyss (תהום *tehom*)
but the breath of *Elohim* was hovering over the face of the waters (המים *hammayim*) [7 x 2 words]

Day 1

Day 4

Day 2

Day 5

Day 3

Day 6

2:1 Summary Epilogue

Thus were finished **the skies and the land** and all their host

2:2-3 Exposition of Epilogue in 3 Lines

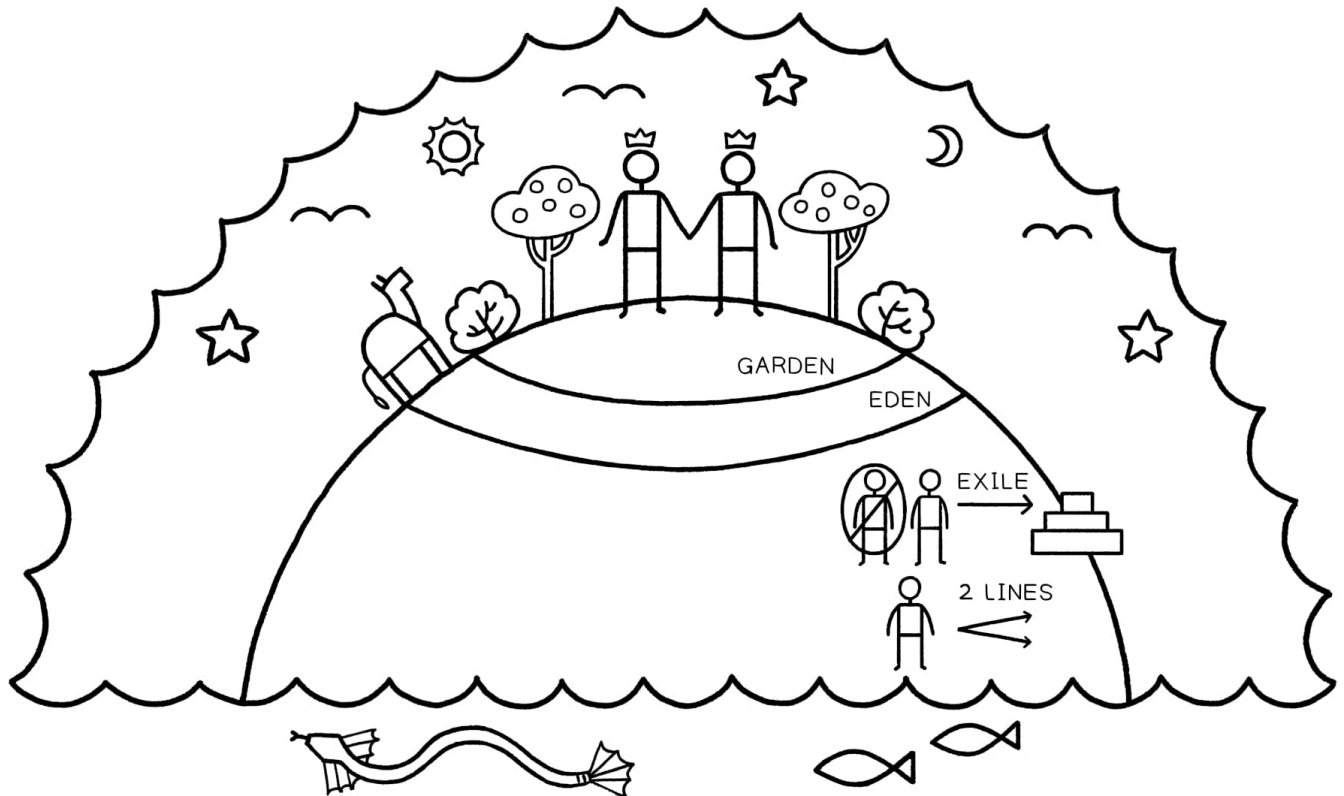
1. And God **completed on the seventh day his work which he had** **made** [7 words]

Genesis 1 Themes. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

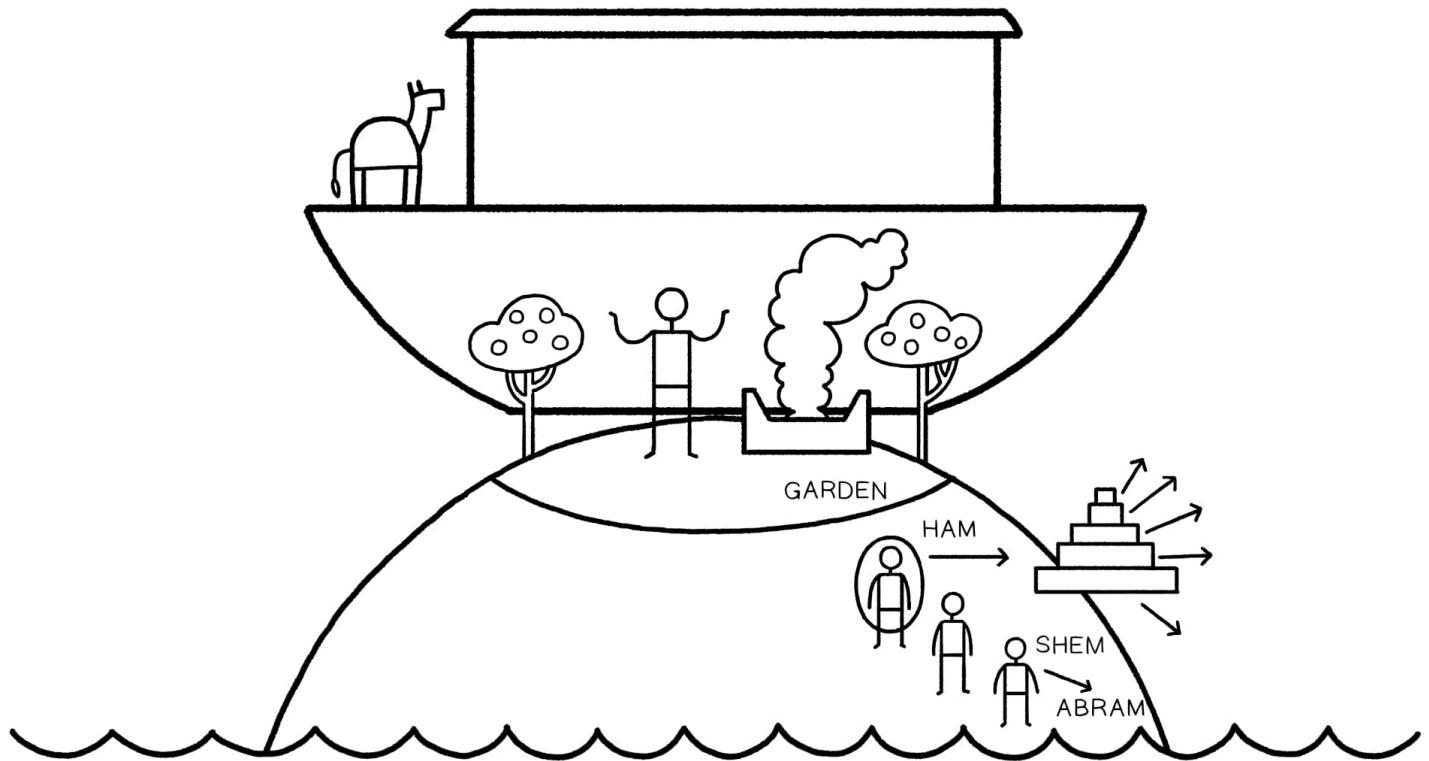
2. And he rested on the seventh day from all his work which he had **made** [7 words]
3. And God blessed the seventh day and sanctified it [7 words]
because on it he rested from all his work which God **created to make** [key word of 1:1]

Genesis 1 Themes. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Exploring Genesis 1-11 Through Illustration



From Adam to Noah. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).



From Noah to Abram. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

The Cyclical Pattern of Genesis 1-11

The Adam and Eve story in Genesis chapters 2-5 fits within a larger pattern at work in Genesis 1-11. Chapters 1-5 play out a cycle of themes, and chapters 6-11 replay and develop the cycle. These symmetrical patterns are created by the dense repetition of key words that indicate the thematic arguments at work in the narrative and show important comparisons.

Unit	Theme
A1 1:1-2:3 Creation of sacred cosmos from chaos waters / human image of God / blessing / fruitful and multiply	Creation and Blessing
B1 2:4-3:24 Mountain-garden temple / sin, nakedness, curse, exile	Failure
B2 4:1-16 Next generation sins / brothers divide / firstborn not chosen / curse, exile	Failure of Next Generation

Macro-Design of Genesis 1-11. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Unit			Theme
	C1	4:17-26 Adam to Lemek: 7 generations + 3 sons / city of Cain / murder / 70 x 7	Non-Chosen
	C2	5:1-32 Adam to Noah: 10 generations + 3 sons / promise of comfort	Chosen
	B3	6:1-8 Cosmic rebellion in Heaven and Earth: sons of God invade the land, leading to the flood	Cosmic Rebellion
A2	6:9-9:19 De-creation by chaos waters and recreation / Noah as new humanity / blessing / fruitful and multiply		Re-Creation and Blessing
	B1	9:20-21 Garden vineyard / sin, nakedness	Failure
	B2	9:22-27 Next generation sins / brothers divide / firstborn not chosen / curse, scattering	Failure of Next Generation
	C1	10:1-32 Noah + 3 sons / 7 generations to Peleg / City of Babylon and Assyria / 70 nations	Non-Chosen
	B3	11:1-9 Cosmic rebellion in Babylon: sons of Adam invade the heavens, leading to the scattering	Cosmic Rebellion
	C2	11:10-26 Shem to Abram: 10 generations / 3 sons	Chosen
A3	12:1-9 Abram as new humanity / blessing / fruitful and multiply		Re-Creation and Blessing
Macro-Design of Genesis 1-11. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).			

“[T]he episodes culled from Hebraic traditions of early history were conceived in two matching sequences (Gen. 1-6 and 6-11) ... Each one of these sequences describes the manner in which humanity was removed progressively from the realm of God [i.e. the garden of Eden and flood], in which he initiated fraternal (and hence human) strife [i.e. Cain and Abel, and Noah’s sons], then divided into tribal and national groupings [Cainite and Shemite genealogies and the Table of Nations], then attempted to restore his divine nature or gain access to the divine realm, but was foiled in this by God [sons of God and Tower of Babel]. In each case, it is the consequence of this hubris which launched God into a decision to focus his relationship with humanity on one person. In the first case (Gen. 6), God destroys mankind, allows it to survive through his choice of Noah, but almost immediately recognizes (Gen. 8:21) that His measure was a shade too drastic. ... [In the second case,] distressed by man’s repeated attempt to unbalance the cosmological order, and no

longer allowing himself the option of totally annihilating mankind, God finally settles on one individual, uproots him from his own kin, and promises him prosperity and continuity in a new land.”

Sasson, J. M., Hess, R. S., and Tsumura, T. (1994). *“The ‘Tower of Babel’ as a Clue to the Redactional Structuring of the Primeval History (Genesis 1: 1-11:9).”* Eisenbrauns.

Genesis 1-3 as the Introduction to the Hebrew Bible

“When understood as the introduction to the Torah and to the Tanakh as a whole, Genesis 1-3 intentionally foreshadows Israel’s failure to keep the Sinai covenant as well as their exile from the promised land in order to point the reader to a future work of God in the ‘last days.’ Adam’s failure to ‘conquer’ (Gen. 1:28) the seditious inhabitant of the land (the serpent), his temptation and violation of the commandments, and his exile from the garden is Israel’s story in miniature ... Just as it was in the beginning ... so it will be in the end. In the conclusion to the Pentateuch, Moses presents Israel’s future apostasy and exile as a certainty (see Deut. 30:1-10) ... This inclusio of pessimism at both ends of the Pentateuch with respect to human abilities to ‘do this and live,’ not only supplies the context for interpreting the Sinai narrative, but also provides the rationale for the need of a new work in the ‘last days,’ whereby God will heal the human heart. Moreover, the groundwork is also laid for the expectation of another ‘Adam’ (a future priest king) to arise from among the people of Israel who will fulfill the creation mandate in the last days. In other words, Genesis 1-3 ... forthrightly prepares the reader to expect that Israel will fail its covenant with God, and so to wait expectantly in exile for a new work of God in the last days.”

Postell, Seth (2011). [*Adam as Israel: Genesis 1-3 as the Introduction to the Torah and Tanakh*](#). Pickwick Publications.

Key Steps for Reading Biblical Literature

Reading Genesis 1-11 teaches us skills for reading the rest of the Bible.

1. Read and re-read, keeping track of two parallel sets of observations: 1) study the text’s cues to discern the design and boundaries of the literary unit and 2) pay close attention to repeated words, images, and narrative elements (plot, character, setting) within each individual literary unit.
2. Let the literary design guide your attention to how repeated words connect multiple literary units together.
3. Repeat, repeat, repeat.
4. Find someone to help you learn about the ancient cultural context of the main themes of the literary units you’re studying. Classroom can help you with this!

Reflection Question

Genesis 1-11 introduces important biblical themes through a cycle that repeats twice. What are some of these repeated themes?